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Tens of Thousands Mourn the Death of Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson

June 13, 1994

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Tens of thousands of Chasidic Jews flocked to Brooklyn's Crown Heights neighborhood to pay tribute to Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, who died here early Sunday morning at the age of 92.

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He left no heirs to assume leadership over the fervently Orthodox movement he headed for 44 years.

As a result, the rebbe's death leaves a gaping leadership vacuum in the Lubavitch movement, which claims hundreds of thousands of followers worldwide, as well as Chabad outreach centers across the globe.

Schneerson had been hospitalized last February after suffering repeated seizures stemming from a stroke he had in 1992, which paralyzed the right side of his body and left him bedridden and unable to communicate.

On March 10, Schneerson suffered a second stroke, which doctors said "seriously weakened" the left side of his body.

Though officials of the Lubavitch movement were characteristically optimistic about the rebbe's condition in his final weeks, when he lay unconscious supported by a respirator, they were forced to concede that his condition had deteriorated.

During the week preceding his death, the rebbe had suffered kidney failure. At 7 p.m. Saturday, he went into cardiac arrest, but his condition was later stabilized. At 12:55 a.m. Sunday, the

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According to police estimates, some 35,000 people were gathered outside Lubavitch headquarters waiting for the coffin to be brought outside.

When the plain pine coffin appeared, the scene became one of emotional mayhem, with women wailing and men pressing forward to touch it.

The 350 police who were on the scene could barely contain the surging crowds, and the pallbearers had difficulty getting the coffin into a waiting hearse.

Despite the sudden rush to the coffin from the sea of black-hatted mourners, no injuries were reported.

The crowds walked behind the slowly moving vehicle, which led them on a procession through the Crown Heights neighborhood.

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procession was over.

Among the dignitaries present at Lubavitch headquarters were New York Mayor Rudolph Giuliani; Benjamin Netanyahu, leader of Israel's opposition Likud bloc; Gad Yaacobi, Israel's ambassador to the United Nations; Colette Avital, Israeli consul general in New York; and Lester Pollack and Malcolm Hoenlein, the chairman and executive vice chairman respectively of the Conference of Presidents of Major American Jewish Organizations.

'THIS IS NOT THE END'

In Israel, the focus of mourning was Kfar Chabad, the village that is the center of the Israeli Lubavitch movement.

On Sunday morning, a stunned follower told Israel Radio: "This is not the end. The rebbe will return. He will be with us from on high. He is but dead in nature; in reality he lives forever."

Crowds of Lubavitcher Chasidim mobbed Ben-Gurion International Airport, offering to pay cash for any ticket that might get them to the funeral.

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Foreign Minister Shimon Peres described the rebbe as "a leader of the highest stature, a great man and a scholar, who labored selflessly on behalf of Jews of the Soviet Union and other countries behind the Iron Curtain."

Representing Israel at the funeral, at the express wish of Rabin and the Chabad movement, was Ashkenazic Chief Rabbi Yisrael Lau.

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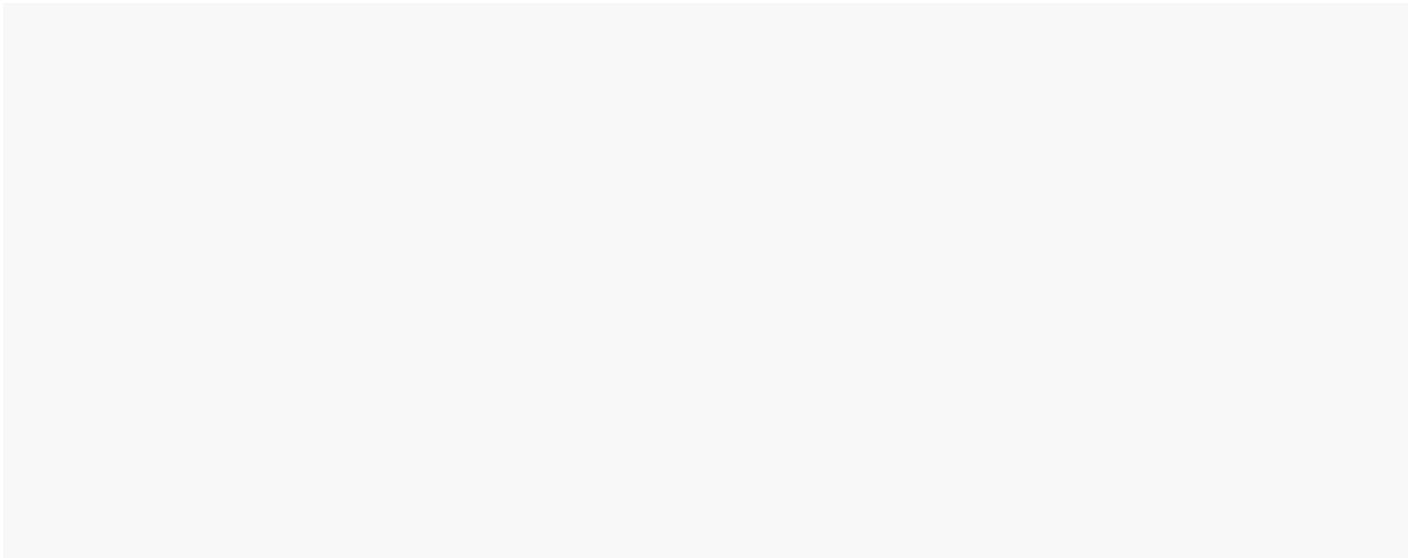
With his long white beard and piercing blue eyes, Schneerson was a charismatic, magnetic presence whose talks and writings on Jewish mysticism and philosophy were central to Lubavitch thought.

When he became immobilized and unable to communicate after the 1992 stroke, his circle of aides rushed to fill the power vacuum.

But in the rebbe's absence, conflict arose over the course of the movement, and particularly over the campaign to declare Schneerson as the Messiah.

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Even those in the Chabad-Lubavitch movement who had not acknowledged that the rebbe was the Messiah nonetheless attributed to him the qualities necessary for being the world's savior. Many others, both within and outside the movement, described him as the foremost Jewish personality of modern times.

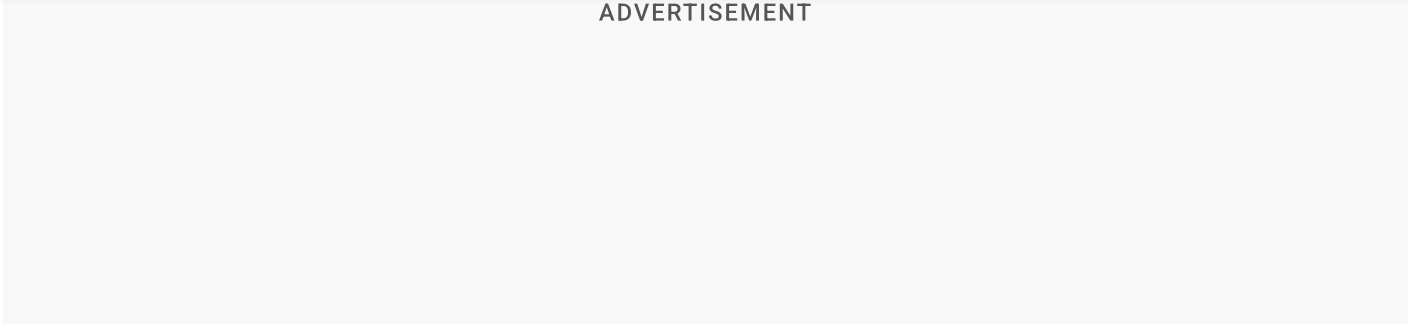
His death leaves nobody at the helm of the Lubavitch movement, which was founded in the 18th century by Rabbi Schneur Zalman of Liadi. Since its founding, the movement has always had a rebbe, or spiritual leader.

NO APPARENT SUCCESSOR

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Sometimes, in the rebbe's presence, they would chant rhythmically, "Long live our master, our teacher, our rabbi, the King Messiah forever and ever."

Much controversy arose when the rebbe's followers burst into this song after Schneerson suffered a stroke two years ago. At the time, the rebbe seemed to pump his one good arm up and down, as though conducting this specific chant.

Many in the Lubavitch community claimed he was thereby acknowledging that he was the Messiah.

His followers cited many worldly occurrences that, to them, proved that the rebbe was the harbinger of the end of days.

The leadership of the Chabad movement was riven by disputes over whether to proclaim him the Messiah.

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At the end of January, a group of followers was going to try to anoint the rebbe as "King Messiah."

Only a last-minute move to prevent the rebbe from appearing prevented the ceremony from taking place.

During the rebbe's final illness, the Lubavitchers, through their telephone hot line, would call for more fasting on Mondays and Thursdays, the reciting of psalms, learning Torah and giving tzedakah, or charity, in multiples of 92, so that the rebbe would reach that age.

The hot-line message was often spoken by a rabbi who was crying.

(Contributing to this report was JTA correspondent Dvorah Getzler in Jerusalem.)

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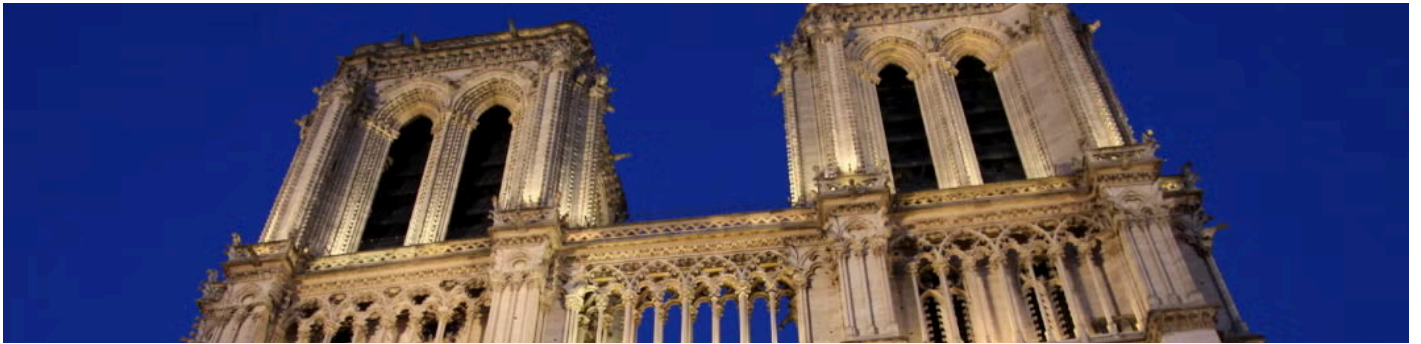
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